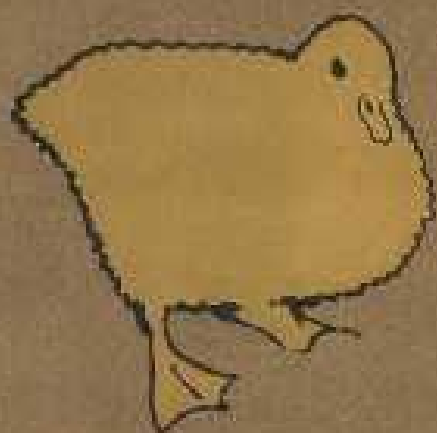


THE SQUARE BOOK OF ANIMALS



By William Nicholson.

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cover

THE SQUARE BOOK OF ANIMALS

By William Nicholson.

RHYMES BY ARTHUR WAUGH.



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AN EXPLANATION

Friend, seek not here (to feed the mind)
Zoology's recondite feasts:
Here you will find but common, kind,
And unsophisticated beasts!

Yet fresh the life of farm and grange
As that which o'er the ocean roams:
Take for a change a narrower range—
An English book for English homes!

THE BRITISH BULL-DOG



You swing the gate;
and there he stands to
greet you,

With growl or grin,
as you are strange or
known:

According to your
merits will he treat
you—

An Englishman
who loves and guards
his own.

THE UN-COMMON CAT

Nine lives they give
the common cat?
There's a rare one
livelier yet than that!
A cat that swings nine
separate tails!
And, when it's let out
of the bag, it rails
With so knotty a
tongue that the culprit
quails!



THE FRIENDLY HEN



Some birds lay eggs in
towering trees,

And some in fens
conceal them;

The hen seeks friendlier
haunts than these,

Where every child can
steal them.

THE LEARNED PIG

The farm's philosophy,
our eyes assure us,
 Is simpler than in
Aristotle's day:
The youngest pigling
follows Epicurus,
 And Bacon's Essays
take the primrose way.



THE BEAUTIFUL SWAN



All day she rules the
pond from edge to edge,
Exerting Beauty's easy
privilege;
Her world a mirror
spread in each direction,
Where she reflects upon
her own reflection.



THE VERY TAME LAMB

All men, said the poet,
are struck at a mint,
And some coins ring
flat that the coiners
embellish:
But the lamb is so tame
he will pardon the hint
—

He'd be best with a
little mint-*sauce* for a
relish!



THE TOILSOME GOAT



"You're a lively kid!" is
the schoolboy jest:

But the kid is driven
to work one day,
And the hours of harness
know little rest

For the stiff goat-
carriage round the bay.

THE LUCKY DUCK

There was a Drake, my
Duck, at Plymouth Hoe
 Played bowls, with
Spain's Armada clear of
Dover!

A gamesome spirit! But
to him we owe
The peace your farm and
all our homesteads
know:

For, ere the Spaniard
reached our wickets, lo!

 Drake
bowled him over!



COCK O' THE NORTH



Cock o' the North! The
dawn is young,
 Grey-glimmering the
pane;
Yet you, with your
discordant tongue,
 Have woken me
again!
Good beasts are silent in
their pens.
Hush! Leave the
boasting to the hens!



THE SIMPLE SHEEP

The sheep's like the man
in the street.
She will follow, and
blunder, and bleat,
 In pursuit of her fate
 At the slaughter-house
gate,
And she learns it too late
to retreat.



THE SERVILE COW



When the cow's in the
farmyard, her sense
Of servility's simply
immense;

But you meet her
again

In the highway or
lane,
And she tosses you over
the fence.

THE GROWING COLT

Rough, shaggy colt: the
world is all before you:

Blithe be your life,
secure of oats and hay;
A little crowd of people
to adore you,

And some green
resting-place at shut of
day!



The sun is low behind the grey-green trees.
And all the farm grows quiet by degrees.
Among their many lessons this is best:
The animals know when and how to rest!

A. W.



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